Greenberg's linguistic universals

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Typology

1. "In declarative sentences with nominal subject and object, the dominant order is almost always one in which the subject precedes the object. "

2. "In languages with prepositions, the genitive almost always follows the governing noun, while in languages with postpositions it almost always precedes."

3. "Languages with dominant VSO order are always prepositional.

4. "With overwhelmingly greater than chance frequency, languages with normal SOV order are postpositional."

5. "If a language has dominant SOV order and the genitive follows the governing noun, then the adjective likewise follows the noun.

6. "All languages with dominant VSO order have SVO as an alternative or as the only alternative basic order."

Syntax

7. "If in a language with dominant SOV order there is no alternative basic order, or only OSV as the alternative, then all adverbial modifiers of the verb likewise precede the verb. (This is the "rigid" subtype of III.)"

8. "When a yes-no question is differentiated from the corresponding assertion by an intonational pattern, the distinctive intonational features of each of these patterns are reckoned from the end of the sentence rather than from the beginning."

9. "With well more than chance frequency, when question particles or affixes are specified in position by reference to the sentence as a whole, if initial, such elements are found in prepositional languages, and, if final, in postpositional."

10. "Question particles or affixes, when specified in position by reference to a particular word in the sentence, almost always follow that word. Such particles do not occur in languages with dominant order VSO."

11. "Inversion of statement order so that verb precedes subject occurs only in languages where the question word or phrase is normally initial. This same inversion occurs in yes-no questions only if it also occurs in interrogative word questions."

12. "If a language has dominant order VSO in declarative sentences, it always puts interrogative words or phrases first in interrogative word questions; if it has dominant order SOV in declarative sentences, there is never such an invariant rule.

13. "If the nominal object always precedes the verb, then verb forms subordinate to the main verb also precede it."

14. "In conditional statements, the conditional clause precedes the conclusion as the normal order in all languages."

15. "In expressions of volition and purpose, a subordinate verbal form always follows the main verb as the normal order except in those languages in which the nominal object always precedes the verb."

16. "In languages with dominant order VSO, an inflected auxiliary always precedes the main verb. In languages with dominant order SOV, an inflected auxiliary always follows the main verb."

17. "With overwhelmingly more than chance frequency, languages with dominant order VSO have the adjective after the noun."

18. "When the descriptive adjective precedes the noun, the demonstrative and the numeral, with overwhelmingly more than chance frequency, do likewise."

19. "When the general rule is that the descriptive adjective follows, there may be a minority of adjectives which usually precede, but when the general rule is that descriptive adjectives precede, there are no exceptions."

20. "When any or all of the items (demonstrative, numeral, and descriptive adjective) precede the noun, they are always found in that order. If they follow, the order is either the same or its exact opposite."

21. "If some or all adverbs follow the adjective they modify, then the language is one in which the qualifying adjective follows the noun and the verb precedes its nominal object as the dominant order."

22. "If in comparisons of superiority the only order, or one of the alternative orders, is standard-marker-adjective, then the language is postpositional. With overwhelmingly more than chance frequency if the only order is adjective-marker-standard, the language is prepositional."

23. "If in apposition the proper noun usually precedes the common noun, then the language is one in which the governing noun precedes its dependent genitive. With much better than chance frequency, if the common noun usually precedes the proper noun, the dependent genitive precedes its governing noun."

24. "If the relative expression precedes the noun either as the only construction or as an alternate construction, either the language is postpositional, or the adjective precedes the noun or both."

25. "If the pronominal object follows the verb, so does the nominal object."

Morphology

26. "If a language has discontinuous affixes, it always has either prefixing or suffixing or both."

27. "If a language is exclusively suffixing, it is postpositional; if it is exclusively prefixing, it is prepositional."

28. "If both the derivation and inflection follow the root, or they both precede the root, the derivation is always between the root and the inflection."

29. "If a language has inflection, it always has derivation."

30. "If the verb has categories of person-number or if it has categories of gender, it always has tense-mode categories."

31. "If either the subject or object noun agrees with the verb in gender, then the adjective always agrees with the noun in gender."

32. "Whenever the verb agrees with a nominal subject or nominal object in gender, it also agrees in number."

33. "When number agreement between the noun and verb is suspended and the rule is based on order, the case is always one in which the verb precedes and the verb is in the singular."

34. "No language has a trial number unless it has a dual. No language has a dual unless it has a plural."

35. "There is no language in which the plural does not have some nonzero allomorphs, whereas there are languages in which the singular is expressed only by zero. The dual and the trial are almost never expressed only by zero."

36. "If a language has the category of gender, it always has the category of number."

37. "A language never has more gender categories in nonsingular numbers than in the singular."

38. "Where there is a case system, the only case which ever has only zero allomorphs is the one which includes among its meanings that of the subject of the intransitive verb."

39. "Where morphemes of both number and case are present and both follow or both precede the noun base, the expression of number almost always comes between the noun base and the expression of case."

40. "When the adjective follows the noun, the adjective expresses all the inflectional categories of the noun. In such cases the noun may lack overt expression of one or all of these categories."

41. "If in a language the verb follows both the nominal subject and nominal object as the dominant order, the language almost always has a case system."

42. "All languages have pronominal categories involving at least three persons and two numbers."

43. "If a language has gender categories in the noun, it has gender categories in the pronoun."

44. "If a language has gender distinctions in the first person, it always has gender distinctions in the second or third person, or in both."

45. "If there are any gender distinctions in the plural of the pronoun, there are some gender distinctions in the singular also."

Linguistic universal

From Wikipedia, the free encyclopedia

A **linguistic universal** is a pattern that occurs systematically across natural languages, potentially true for all of them. For example, *All languages have nouns and verbs*, or *If a language is spoken, it has consonants and vowels.* Research in this area of linguistics is closely tied to the study of linguistic typology, and intends to reveal generalizations across languages, likely tied to cognition, perception, or other abilities of the mind. The field was largely pioneered by the linguist Joseph Greenberg, who derived a set of forty-five basic universals, mostly dealing with syntax (see the list), from a study of some thirty languages.

Terminology

Linguists distinguish between two kinds of universals: **absolute** (opposite: **statistical**, often called **tendencies**) and **implicational** (opposite **non-implicational**). Absolute universals apply to every known language and are quite few in number; an example is *All languages have pronouns*. An implicational universal applies to languages with a particular feature that is always accompanied by another feature, such as *If a language has trial grammatical number, it also has dual grammatical number*, while non-implicational universals just state the existence (or non-existence) of one particular feature.

Also in contrast to absolute universals are **tendencies**, statements that may not be true for all languages, but nevertheless are far too common to be the result of chance. They also have implicational and non-implicational forms. An example of the latter would be *The vast majority of languages have nasal consonants*.[1] However, most tendencies, like their universal counterparts, are implicational. For example, *With overwhelmingly-greater-than-chance frequency, languages with normal SOV order are postpositional*. Strictly speaking, a tendency is not a kind of universal, but exceptions to most statements called universals can be found. For example, Latin is an SOV language with prepositions. Often it turns out that these exceptional languages are undergoing a shift from one type of language to another. In the case of Latin, its descendant Romance languages switched to SVO, which is a much more common order among prepositional languages.

Universals may also be **bidirectional** or **unidirectional**. In a bidirectional universal two features each imply the existence of each other. For example, languages with postpositions usually have SOV order, and likewise SOV languages usually have postpositions. The implication works both ways, and thus the universal is bidirectional. By contrast, in a unidirectional universal the implication works only one way. Languages that place relative clauses before the noun they modify again usually have SOV order, so pre-nominal relative clauses imply SOV. On the other hand, SOV languages worldwide show little preference for pre-nominal relative clauses, and thus SOV implies little about the order of relative clauses. As the implication works only one way, the proposed universal is a unidirectional one.

Linguistic universals in syntax are sometimes held up as evidence for universal grammar (although epistemological arguments are more common). Other explanations for linguistic universals have been proposed, for example, that linguistic universals tend to be properties of language that aid communication. If a language were to lack one of these properties, it has been argued, it would probably soon evolve into a language having that property.[*citation needed*]

Michael Halliday has argued for a distinction between **descriptive** and **theoretical** categories in resolving the matter of the existence of linguistic universals, a distinction he takes from J.R. Firth and Louis Hjelmslev. He argues that "theoretical categories, and their inter-relations construe an abstract model of language...; they are interlocking and mutually defining". Descriptive categories, by contrast, are those set up to describe particular languages. He argues that "When people ask about "universals", they usually mean descriptive categories that are assumed to be found in all languages. The problem is there is no mechanism for deciding how much alike descriptive categories from different languages have to be before they are said to be "the same thing" [2]

In semantics

In the domain of semantics, research into linguistic universals has taken place in a number of ways. Some linguists, starting with Leibniz, have pursued the search for a hypothetic irreducible semantic core of all languages. A modern variant of this approach can be found in the Natural Semantic Metalanguage of Wierzbicka and associates.[3] Other lines of research suggest cross-linguistic tendencies to use body part terms metaphorically as adpositions,[4] or tendencies to have morphologically simple words for cognitively salient concepts.[5] The human body, being a physiological universal, provides an ideal domain for research into semantic and lexical universals. In a seminal study, Cecil H. Brown (1976) proposed a number of universals in the semantics of body part terminology, including the following: in any language, there will be distinct terms for BODY, HEAD, ARM, EYES, NOSE, and MOUTH; if there is a distinct term for FOOT, there will be a distinct term for HAND; similarly, if there are terms for INDIVIDUAL TOES, then there are terms for INDIVIDUAL FINGERS. Subsequent research has shown that most of these features have to be considered cross-linguistic tendencies rather than true universals. Several languages, for example Tidore and Kuuk Thaayorre, lack a general term meaning 'body'. On the basis of such data it has been argued that the highest level in the partonomy of body part terms would be the word for 'person'.[6]